

already learnt. POPFile uses Bayesian statistical analysis to classify incoming messages in user-defined categories.

So what has it learnt? What you teach it, of course! You see, when you install POPFile, it can do nothing. What happens is that it shows you mail that has just arrived, and how it was classified; you change the classification, and that is one ‘lesson’ that POPFile learns. Over a few hundred ‘lessons’, the program becomes competent enough.

OK, if it sounds like we jumped the gun, let’s begin at the beginning. What you need is a spam-catching tool for your e-mail client. POPFile is one of the best ones out there. Run the Windows installer provided on the DVD, and head to <http://popfile.sourceforge.net/manual/email.html/> for instructions. (You’ll see tabs on this page starting from ‘Installation’, and you might want to start off there, although it’s pretty straightforward.)



POPFile doesn’t just classify mail as ‘good’ and ‘spam’; it puts them into the buckets you create

Refer the screenshot alongside. During setup, POPFile asks what buckets you want to create. Don’t be put off by the new word—a bucket is nothing but an abstract folder that POPFile uses to dump mail into. So if you have the ‘Work’, ‘Personal’, ‘General’ and ‘Spam’ buckets, POPFile knows that it will be classifying mail into one of these four. You can have as many buckets as you want.

Now, POPFile automatically detects the mail clients you have installed, and asks which one(s) to integrate with. You don’t need